

A. PRABHAKARAN RAO



Swinging His Star Power

HYDERABAD The makeover is on. After three decades in films, Telugu actor Chiranjeevi is trying to walk in the footsteps of thespian-turned-politician N.T. Rama Rao who took Andhra Pradesh by storm way back in 1982.

Five days short of his 54th birthday on August 22, the 148-movie-old Chiranjeevi announced his arrival on the political stage by promising pro-poor policies to build a Santosha Andhra Pradesh, a subtle shift

from the Harita Andhra Pradesh promised by Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy and the Swarna Andhra Pradesh spoken about by his predecessor and TDP President N. Chandrababu Naidu. The name of the party, the flag, the rules and party policies will be announced on August 26 in Tirupati.

"I have no political experience but I have a heart that responds to the needs of the people and I have the determination to

POLITICAL MOVE: Chiranjeevi

serve them. It is God's decree," said the actor, expecting the spiel to be the emotional tug to win voters. "It will be a historic blunder if I do not respond to the call of the people at a time when politics had become the hunting ground of selfish persons," he said. He referred to NTR as his inspiration, and said former president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam was the driving force for him to turn to politics.

However, Reddy was quick to dismiss Chiranjeevi's political foray. "We are the reigning champions. Anyone is free to challenge us. The Congress Government has proved itself. No one can surprise us," he said. Unfazed, Naidu added, "Ours is the party which fought for Telugu's pride. As long as people are with us, nobody can ruin our prospects."

But with cries of "Jai Chiranjeeva" and his emergence as a politician, it will only be at the polls where his star power is put to the true test.

by Amarnath K. Menon

SIGNPOSTS

WON: By D. Harika and Abhijeet Gupta, the World Junior Chess Championship titles in the girls and open sections in Gaziantep, Turkey.

AWARDED: To Gandhian Anna Hazare, the Rajiv Gandhi Award for social work. The award was constituted in 1995.



APPOINTED: Dr Uday Bodhankar as the secretary-general of the Commonwealth Association for Mental Handicap and Developmental Disability. It has a membership of 53 Commonwealth countries.

DIED: Habib Milan, 139, India's oldest surviving man. Born on May 28, 1870 at Rajgarh in Rajasthan, he had been a clarinet player for the Jaipur royal family.

DIED: Bhag Singh, 82, dramatist, writer, actor and director of Punjabi films.

VIS-A-VIS ARUN JAITLEY BJP general secretary **versus** MANMOHAN SINGH prime minister

It's a day of shame for the UPA. At least three UPA members support SIMI while a fourth, PDP, talks of marching to Muzaffarabad in PoK.



Parties should shun divisive politics and strive for a permanent solution to the crisis plaguing Jammu and Kashmir.

EPILOGUE: Instead of fighting among themselves, parties should unite to resolve the Kashmir imbroglio.